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ANCESTORS OF INDIAN RAILWAYS

Beyond the Beginnings

THE RED HILLS RAILWAY

The Red Hills are called so because of the colour of their soil and rocks. Around 1836, the construction of a rudimentary railway line was started in these hills within the city of Madras to carry hard laterite used as road-building material. It was completed a year later, in 1837. The line, though basic and experimental, remains the oldest documented railway in India today. Makeshift trains actually ran and ferried people on this line, and even though they were mostly workers, it was considered a success. The 16 January 1838 edition of the *Madras Herald* gives an interesting account of a self-propelled train, run with the help of wind-powered rotary machines. [10]

The following is an excerpt:

> We had another most gratifying sail on the Red Hill Railway last Monday afternoon. There was a modest breeze from the N by E, and as the road runs very nearly at right angles, or E by S and W by N, the wind was favourable going and returning. The carriage is a small conveyance fitted up with springs; it is large enough to carry four or five persons, and is furnished with a small lug sail. The wheels are low, and in some places the road has suffered much by the last monsoon, yet in spite of these obstacles, the carriage travelled at least twelve miles an hour; and when the wind freshened, it was necessary to ease off the sheet to prevent the vehicle going at a greater velocity than would be agreeable, or, in the present state of the rails, safe.

The line was closed by 1845. But it was on these lines that Captain Cotton conducted several experiments with the rotary steam-powered engines,